

Concept note for the Horizon Europe consortium

Working title: Pressures and Adaptive Resilience of Asia-Pacific Democracies and Europe (PARADE)

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2026-09-04

Abstract

This document sets out the concept and strategy behind PARADE, a proposed Horizon Europe Cluster 2 consortium on AI and democratic resilience. Chapter 1 defines democratic resilience, defines AI as both risk and opportunity across five pillars, and connects the two through two mechanisms: AI-accelerated informationalism and AI-accelerated administrative capacity. Chapter 2 sets out the work packages. Chapter 3 highlights the project’s relevance by summarizing its two-region design, why it matters to the EU, why now, why Australia, and why the University of Melbourne. Chapter 4 covers who is on the team, the gaps, and who to contact next.

1 AI and Democratic Resilience: Risk and Opportunity

1.1 Democratic Resilience

Boese et al.’s two-stage model is simple, tested on V-Dem’s global data, and comes from our own team (Boese et al., 2021). Based on this, democratic resilience has two stages:

1. Onset resilience: a democracy avoids sliding into autocratization at all.
2. Breakdown resilience: once sliding has started, a democracy stops it before full breakdown, or reverses it.

For example, Hungary lost onset resilience: V-Dem downgraded it to an electoral autocracy in 2019, the first EU state ever reclassified from democracy (Nord et al., 2025). Poland lost onset resilience in 2015, but kept breakdown resilience: voters reversed the decline at the 2023 election (Lührmann & Lindberg, 2019; Nord et al., 2025).

Resilience is not just a stock of protective features. It is whether the system’s own feedback loops still work. Easton’s (1965) classic model treats a political system as inputs — demands and support from citizens — converted into outputs, fed back into the next round of inputs. A resilient democracy is one where that loop still closes: elections, participation, and responsiveness let citizens correct course before or after a slide starts. We keep “democracy” broad here, not just its liberal variant (Nord et al., 2025). The five pillars, not a fixed threshold, are where that line matters. Information environments carry the input side, governance the output side, and participation and

attitudes and behaviour carry the loop back. AI can strengthen or break the loop at any point (Figure 1).

Three recent frameworks group resilience into different arenas. Croissant and Lott (2026) use institutions, political actors, civil society, and political community, across 103 countries since 2000. Summerfield et al. (2025) use epistemic, material, and foundational impacts. Biddle et al. (2025), building on the Australian Government’s own framework (Australian Government Department of Home Affairs, Strengthening Democracy Taskforce, 2024), use trusted institutions, credible information, and social inclusion, and name AI as a pressure on all three. None of the three treats public administration or the policy process as its own arena. We cover this in our fifth pillar and the proposed Work Package 7 (see below).

Inspired by Gerschewski’s (2013) three pillars of autocratic stability, we reverse the framework, apply it to democracies instead of autocracies, and propose five pillars of democratic resilience. The five pillars are information environments (media, journalism, algorithmic curation, political communication), attitudes and behaviour (trust, opinion, polarisation, electoral behaviour, support for democratic norms), participation (voice, deliberation, institutional listening, inclusion), power (surveillance, digital repression, platform power, regulation), and governance (automated decision-making, election administration, public service delivery, AI in policy design). AI runs under all five, as both risk and opportunity. We score each pillar separately rather than building one aggregate index: a diagnostic needs to show which pillar is under pressure, not just whether resilience overall is up or down. Figure 1 illustrates these pillars.

Democratic resilience				
Information environments	Attitudes & behaviour	Participation	Power	Governance
<i>media</i> <i>journalism</i> <i>algorithmic curation</i> <i>political communication</i>	<i>trust</i> <i>opinion</i> <i>polarisation</i> <i>electoral behaviour</i> <i>support for democratic norms</i>	<i>voice</i> <i>deliberation</i> <i>institutional listening</i> <i>inclusion</i>	<i>surveillance</i> <i>digital repression</i> <i>platform power</i> <i>regulation</i>	<i>automated decision-making</i> <i>election administration</i> <i>public service delivery</i> <i>AI in policy design</i>
AI: risk and opportunity				

Figure 1: Five pillars of democratic resilience, adapted from Gerschewski’s (2013) three pillars of autocratic stability.

1.2 AI as Risk and Opportunity

AI here means machine-learning systems, generative models, and recommender systems (High-Level Expert Group on Artificial Intelligence, 2019; OECD, 2019).

Risk:

- Zuboff (2019): platforms extract data and predict behaviour, reshaping public life.
- Woolley and Howard (2018): the standard cross-country study of AI-enabled political manipulation.
- Feldstein (2021): how states use AI for authoritarian control.
- Chesney and Citron (2019): deepfakes as a distinct threat to democracy.
- Bak-Coleman et al. (2021): algorithms shape collective political behaviour.
- Yang, Durotoye and Gil de Zúñiga (2025): a recent survey of AI's effects on democracy, covering harm and benefit.
- Altman (2026): generative AI can turn direct-democracy tools, like referenda, into instability engines.

Opportunity:

- Margetts and Dorobantu (2019): AI can make government more responsive and fair, if governed well.
- Noveck (2021): AI-assisted civic participation and public problem-solving.
- OECD (2025): AI-run deliberation platforms can process large citizen input while protecting minority views.
- Fact-checking tools run on the same technology that produces disinformation. This dual use is the point: Work Package 2 (Chapter 2) recruits from both sides of it.

Figure 2 shows this dual nature.

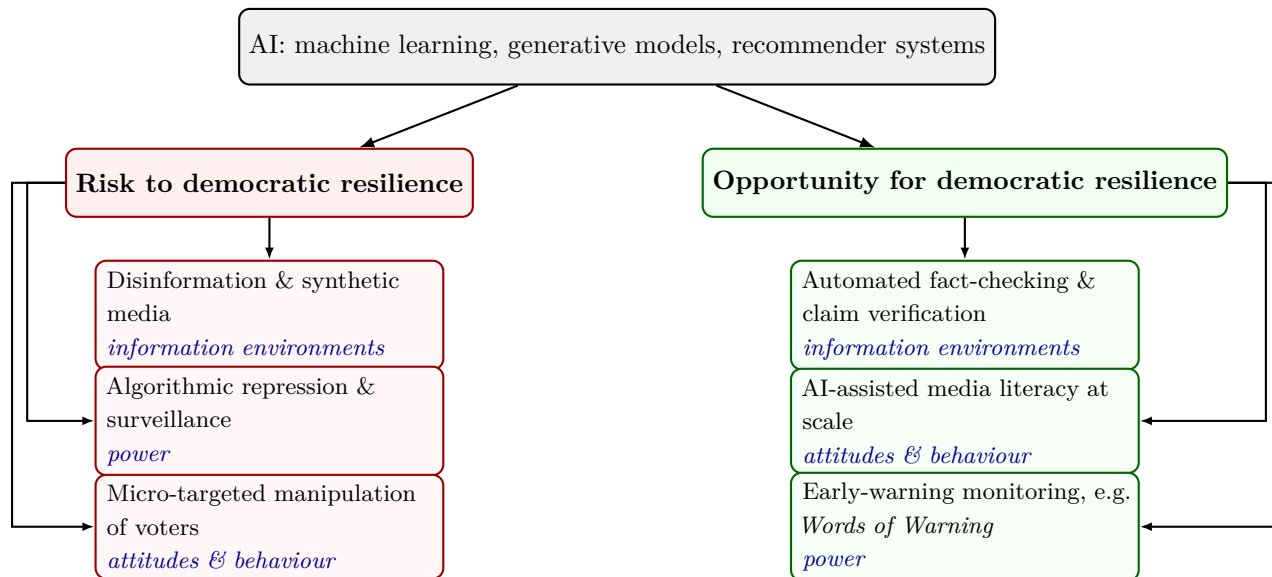


Figure 2: AI as risk and opportunity for democratic resilience, by pillar. Same technology, opposite uses.

1.3 The Bridge: Two Mechanisms

Two recent works cover similar ground but do not make this connection. Jungherr (2023) gives a framework for AI’s effects on self-rule, equality, and elections. Wiewiura, Jørgensen and Ploug (2026) review the wider debate, but stop short of a resilience framework. We connect AI directly to onset/breakdown resilience. As far as we know, no one has done this before (further checks needed).

AI connects to resilience through two mechanisms, each dual-use, together spanning all five pillars:

1. AI-accelerated informationalism (information environments, power, attitudes and behaviour, participation — Easton’s input and feedback side): Garbe and Maerz (2026; Maerz, 2026) define authoritarian informationalism as three practices regimes use to hold power: manipulation, surveillance, control. AI adds no fourth practice; it makes these three cheaper and faster. The same capability runs both ways: pattern-detection that targets disinformation can just as easily flag it (Figure 2).
2. AI-accelerated administrative capacity (governance — Easton’s output side): a different capability, not manipulation, surveillance, or control, but the speed and accuracy of decisions and services (George & Klaus, 2026; Margetts & Dorobantu, 2019). The same automation that speeds up decisions can make them opaque and hard to contest instead (Table 2).

Figure 3 puts informationalism on the resilience diagram: onset and breakdown are regime-level transitions, and informationalism’s three practices act directly on them. Administrative capacity works differently — it changes how well the system functions inside a given regime, rather than driving the transition itself — so Figure 4’s 2x2 carries it instead, sorted by our five pillars.

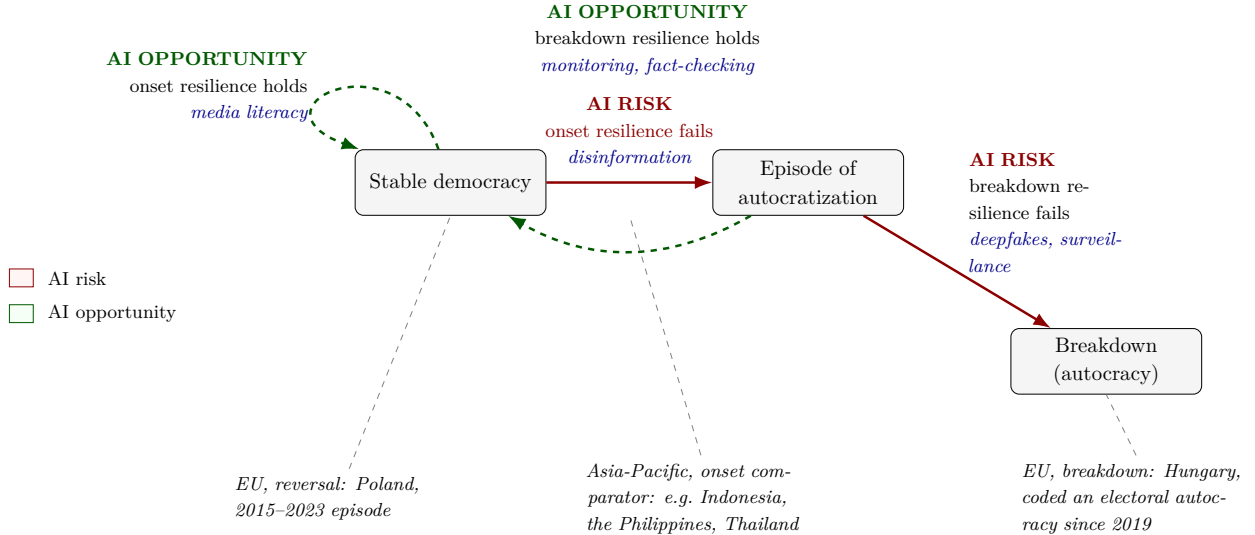


Figure 3: Onset and breakdown resilience (adapted from Boese et al., 2021). Regional cases mapped onto PARADE’s two-region design (3.2).

	Onset stage	Breakdown stage
AI as risk	Curated disinformation erodes baseline trust (<i>information environments</i>); micro-targeted manipulation weakens support for democratic norms (<i>attitudes & behaviour</i>)	Deepfakes and coordinated disinformation suppress mobilisation (<i>information environments, participation</i>); surveillance and platform power entrench control (<i>power</i>); opaque automated decisions entrench unaccountable authority (<i>governance</i>)
AI as opportunity	Automated fact-checking and media literacy build baseline resistance (<i>information environments</i>); AI-assisted deliberation broadens participation (<i>participation</i>)	Early-warning monitoring (e.g. <i>Words of Warning</i>) detects and helps reverse an episode (<i>power</i>); institutional listening rebuilds trust (<i>governance, attitudes & behaviour</i>)

Figure 4: Risk/opportunity by onset/breakdown.

2 Overview of Potential Work Packages

Table 1 sets out working themes for the November/December workshops, mapped to the consortium’s team so far. Chapter 4 points to gaps in this regard and includes a list of whom we should contact next to fill those gaps.

Table 1: Draft PARADE work packages.

WP	Pillar / theme	Core team (confirmed, budgeted)	Deliverables	Budget
WP1	Developing the PARADE framework on AI and democratic resilience	Maerz (UoM) ; Groemping (Griffith); Sanhueza Petrarca (ANU); Gerschewski (WZB); Knutsen (Oslo); Daly (UoM, not yet contacted — Democratic Decay & Renewal)	Peer-reviewed framework paper; policy brief series for EU and Australian officials	€150,000
WP2	Pillar 1: Information environments	Carson (UoM) ; Hovy (UoM); Benoit (SMU); Leckie (UoM); de Kock (UoM); Baes (UoM); Glazunova (UoM); Saletta (UoM); Trijsburg (UoM); Maerz (UoM); Bailo (Sydney); Notely (WSU)	Deployable fact-checking and platform-monitoring toolkit for newsrooms and regulators; peer-reviewed disinformation dataset and paper	€700,000

Table 1: Draft PARADE work packages.

WP	Pillar / theme	Core team (confirmed, budgeted)	Deliverables	Budget
WP3	Pillar 2: Attitudes and behaviour	Groemping (Griffith); Sanhueza Petrarca (ANU); Martinez i Coma (Griffith); Jackman (Uni Canberra); Chernykh (ANU); Biddle (ANU); Nai (ASCoR, online); Australian Electoral Commission (not yet contacted — via Daly’s ERRN)	Public-trust index and policy brief for electoral commissions; survey-experimental paper on AI and political trust	€550,000
WP4	Pillar 3: Participation	Kołczyńska (Poland); Webb (Uni Canberra, Centre for Deliberative Democracy); Rejón (UoM); Miletic (UoM); Guasti (Czechia); Groemping (Griffith)	AI-assisted deliberation pilot with a partner government body; participation-design toolkit; peer-reviewed evaluation paper on the pilot	€350,000
WP5	Pillar 4: Power — surveillance and digital repression	Wilson (Gothenburg); Boese (WZB); Knutsen (Oslo); Maerz (UoM); Sanhueza Petrarca (ANU)	Early-warning briefing for human-rights and civil-society monitors on digital repression; peer-reviewed paper on AI-enabled digital repression	€320,000
WP6	Pillar 4: Power — platform political economy and regulation	Postnikov (UoM); Walter (UoM); Helberger (University of Amsterdam, not yet contacted — proposed co-lead); Goldenfein (UoM, not yet contacted — platform and data governance); Patterson (UoM, not yet contacted — AI governance and regulation)	Policy recommendations comparing platform-accountability and AI-specific regulatory models, for DFAT and the European Commission; comparative regulatory-diffusion paper	€220,000
WP7	Pillar 5: Governance — public policy and AI literacy in higher education	Williams (UoM); Fu (UoM); Hovy (UoM); Noveck (Northeastern, not yet confirmed — AI-assisted public problem-solving); Goldenfein (UoM, not yet contacted — platform and data governance)	AI-literacy training module for public servants; governance guidelines for universities; peer-reviewed paper on AI in research governance	€320,000
WP8	Methods and tools: quantitative and text infrastructure for the project	Sebők (ELTE / CEU Democracy Institute); Maerz (UoM); Benoit (SMU); Knutsen (Oslo); Boese (WZB); Jackman (Uni Canberra); Kołczyńska (Poland)	Open-source text-analysis toolkit and training workshops for partner institutions; methods paper documenting the toolkit	€380,000
WP9	Two-region synthesis (EU / Asia-Pacific)	Croissant (Heidelberg); Guasti and Farag (Czechia); Webb (Uni Canberra); Strating (La Trobe); Miletic (UoM); Sanhueza Petrarca (ANU); Groemping (Griffith); ISEAS – Yusof Ishak Institute (Singapore, not yet contacted — proposed co-lead)	Joint EU–Asia-Pacific policy report, briefed to DFAT and the European Commission; peer-reviewed comparative synthesis paper	€360,000

Table 1: Draft PARADE work packages.

WP	Pillar / theme	Core team (confirmed, budgeted)	Deliverables	Budget
WP10	Project management, coordination and ethics	Maerz (UoM) ; Project Manager (TBA); O'Malley (UoM); Major Grants Initiative (UoM)	Consortium agreement; periodic reporting; ethics and DMP deliverables	€350,000
Total (estimated)				€3,700,000

3 Relevance of the Project

PARADE targets two Horizon Europe Cluster 2 calls, in this order:

1. Main target: [HORIZON-CL2-2027-02-DEMOCRACY-09](#), an open, two-stage call on reinvigorating and shielding European democracy. Total indicative budget €22m, expected EU contribution €2.0–3.7m per project — roughly six to nine projects funded (European Commission, 2025). Eligibility requires at least one beneficiary with a policy-making role and one civil-society organisation; PARADE does not yet have either (4.1). Opens 2 March 2027, first-stage deadline 4 May 2027.
2. Fallback: [HORIZON-CL2-2027-01-DEMOCRACY-04](#), a narrower, single-stage call on AI, cyberviolence, and deepfakes. Budget about €3.5–4m per project. Opens 13 May 2027, deadline 23 September 2027.

PARADE is written for the general call. If it does not fit, the same consortium and framework adapt to the narrower one with less rework than starting fresh.

3.1 The Two-Region Design

The two-region design is PARADE’s defining feature, and the best answer to: why should an Australian institution lead this, not a European one? A real comparative study of the Asia-Pacific and Europe needs people already working in the Asia-Pacific, existing ties to regional think tanks and survey infrastructure, and closeness to the region’s media and policy world. This consortium has all three (3.4).

The two regions test different parts of Figure 4:

- EU cases, mostly breakdown resilience: Several EU states are already inside, or have recently come out of, autocratization episodes: Hungary’s long decline; Poland’s 2015–2023 episode and its reversal (Figure 3). Risk side: documented AI-generated disinformation and deepfakes in EU states. Opportunity side: EU-based fact-checking and platform-accountability work.
- Asia-Pacific cases (Southeast Asia, Australia, New Zealand), mostly onset resilience: Hybrid and competitive-authoritarian regimes in Southeast Asia (Schedler, 2013) are the sharper test of whether AI-accelerated informationalism changes the odds that a new episode starts. Opportunity side: Australian fact-checking work, the Centre for Deliberative Democracy’s AI-assisted deliberation (Webb, WP4), and Andrea Carson’s *Asia-Pacific News Pulse* — a

planned annual report on news use, information resilience, and public trust across Indonesia, Thailand, the Philippines, and South Korea, built to close the Asia-Pacific gap in the Reuters Institute Digital News Report. No EU-based team can build this kind of survey infrastructure on this timeline.

Table 2: Two-region comparisons, sorted by pillar.

Pillar	Risk-side comparison	Opportunity-side comparison
Information environments	AI-generated disinformation and deepfakes: Southeast Asia vs. EU states	Fact-checking and platform-accountability tools: Australia vs. EU newsrooms
Attitudes and behaviour	Micro-targeted manipulation eroding trust and support for democratic norms: Southeast Asian social-media use vs. EU electoral campaigns	Media and AI literacy building resistance to manipulation: Australian and EU public-education initiatives
Participation	AI-curated feeds narrowing political attention and civic voice: Southeast Asian platforms vs. EU-regulated feeds	AI-assisted deliberation and citizen listening: Australia (Centre for Deliberative Democracy; <i>Asia-Pacific News Pulse</i>) vs. EU civic-tech pilots
Power (regulation)	Two regulatory frontiers, not one: Australia’s platform-accountability model (the world-first 2021 News Media Bargaining Code (Bossio et al., 2022) and the world-first 2025 under-16 social media ban (Weeramanthri, 2026)) vs. the EU’s AI-specific model (the AI Act, AI Office, and content-moderation rules under the Digital Services Act (2022))	Evidence on which approach works better: platform accountability or AI-specific rules. Feeds WP6
Governance	Opaque automated decision-making in migration, welfare, and election administration: Southeast Asian e-government rollouts vs. EU public-sector AI deployments	AI-assisted policy design and public-service delivery, tested for fairness and transparency: comparative Australia–EU pilots. Feeds WP7

DEMOCRACY-09 asks proposals to build on prior Horizon-funded work without duplicating it (European Commission, 2025). Most competing teams are EU-only or EU-plus-one (this needs more research). They can only account for one column of Figure 4 - PARADE accounts for both.

3.2 Why It Matters to the EU

Why should the EU fund Asia-Pacific research instead of more EU-only work?

1. It is already an EU priority. The EU Strategy for Cooperation in the Indo-Pacific names digital governance and partnerships as a priority (European Commission and High Representative of the Union for Foreign Affairs and Security Policy, 2021).
2. It tests the EU’s own reach. The Brussels Effect (Bradford, 2020) — the EU’s ability to set global standards through its own rules (the AI Act, the Digital Services Act (2022)) — only shows up if it travels beyond the EU. PARADE tests that directly.

3. It matters for EU digital diplomacy. Other digital-governance models compete for influence in Southeast Asia. Evidence on how AI pressures and responses play out there feeds directly into the EU’s own position.
4. It gives the sharpest test. Onset resilience is easier to test where regime paths actually differ, as they do across Southeast Asia, than by re-running EU cases. Australia and New Zealand add a further comparison inside the same region.

3.3 Why Now

The EU’s Democracy Shield and the AI Act timeline make 2026–27 the moment EU funders want this research: the call names AI’s impact on democracy, and democratic resilience and civic preparedness, as priorities (European Commission, 2025). In 2024, about two billion voters across fifty countries went to the polls. V-Dem’s latest report finds autocracies now outnumber democracies worldwide for the first time in two decades; the average world citizen’s level of democracy is back to 1985 (Nord et al., 2025). Guardrails once thought stable in established democracies are more fragile than assumed (Levitsky & Ziblatt, 2018). Whether AI-accelerated informationalism and administrative capacity affect onset or breakdown resilience is squarely inside the call’s scope.

3.4 Why Led from Australia

Section 3.2 makes the main case. Five more reasons:

1. First-mover eligibility. Australia joins Horizon Europe Pillar II from January 2027. Australian institutions can lead Cluster 2 consortia on equal terms with EU states for the first time.
2. Real seniority, not borrowed credibility. The Australian lead was Deputy Director of the V-Dem Institute (2020–21) and remains a V-Dem Research Associate. The team includes a V-Dem project PI (Knutsen, Oslo) and the WZB co-authors of both frameworks this proposal builds on (Boese et al., 2021; Garbe & Maerz, 2026). The lead’s EU policy record is real, not aspirational: a 2025 report for the Robert Schuman Centre and the European Commission on AI-powered threats to democracy (2025), co-authored with team member Chernykh (ANU, WP3) and Sanhueza Petrarca.
3. Genuine independence. The call wants international cooperation and no duplication. An EU-only team cannot show independence. An Australian hub with real Asia-Pacific content can.
4. Access an EU team cannot claim. Bec Strating (La Trobe, WP9) directs La Trobe Asia and leads the DFAT-funded Blue Security network on Indo-Pacific maritime security; that access, plus existing regional research links and the *Asia-Pacific News Pulse* (3.2), give this team a starting point a Berlin- or Gothenburg-led bid would have to build from zero.
5. Value for money. An Australian hub delivers EU-grade science at a different cost base than the EU capitals hosting most competing teams.
6. Two regulatory frontiers, not one. Australia’s News Media Bargaining Code (2021) was the world’s first platform-payment law for news, later copied by Canada (Bossio et al., 2022). Its under-16 social media ban (2025) was the world’s first of its kind (Weeramanthri, 2026). The

EU leads on AI-specific rules instead, through the AI Act and the AI Office. A team based in only one place can draw on only one of these. PARADE draws on both (Table 2).

3.5 Why the University of Melbourne

UoM has what this needs in one place: the Centre for Advancing Journalism (Carson) for disinformation and media-industry ties, plus Carson’s *Asia-Pacific News Pulse* (3.2); Melbourne Connect and the School of Computing and Information Systems (Hovy, Leckie, de Kock, Baes) for computational and NLP infrastructure; and Maerz’s ARC DECRA project *Words of Warning*, which already uses LLMs to monitor democratic discourse — a working example of the opportunity side of Figure 2. Maerz’s V-Dem history and EU policy record mean the Australian lead already has working ties to V-Dem Gothenburg, WZB Berlin, and the European Commission.

4 Filling Gaps in the Consortium

4.1 Gaps

Six gaps stand out.

1. Eligibility. DEMOCRACY-09 requires a public-body beneficiary and a civil-society beneficiary (European Commission, 2025); the consortium (Table 1) has neither confirmed. Without both, the proposal is inadmissible, not just weaker.
2. Public body. Fastest fix: an Australian electoral commission, via Tom Daly’s standing ERRN partnership (below) — also becomes WP3’s own audience.
3. Civil society / Southeast Asia institution. Only individual contacts so far, not an institution. ISEAS – Yusof Ishak Institute (Singapore, below) could fill both roles, leading a work package.
4. WP6. Thin and entirely UoM: no international team member, and no EU AI Act, Digital Services Act, or platform-law expertise, a DEMOCRACY-04 priority (European Commission, 2025). Helberger, Goldenfein, and Paterson (below) fix this.
5. General AI governance. No one works on AI in public administration. Wagner (below) is the fit.
6. Southeast Asia expertise. No confirmed survey partner matches ANU’s ANUpoll (Biddle, WP3), ahead of the *Asia-Pacific News Pulse* going live.

Two smaller gaps: AI-enabled gendered harm (Citron, below) and computer-vision detection for fake video and audio, both DEMOCRACY-04 priorities (Chesney & Citron, 2019; European Commission, 2025).

4.2 Who to Contact Next

Eleven names, high priority only. Medium- and low-priority names are tracked outside this document.

Name	Institution / Country	Gap addressed
Aries Arugay	University of the Philippines Diliman; ISEAS – Yusof Ishak Institute	Southeast Asia-based partner, the biggest open gap; his own work on Philippine democratic erosion and resilience maps onto WP9
Lee Sue-Ann	ISEAS – Yusof Ishak Institute	Second Southeast Asia-based option, on AI and political narratives — deepens WP2/WP9
Natali Helberger	University of Amsterdam	Platform political economy and regulation; ERC-funded, studies platforms as political actors with real opinion power — the genuine international co-lead WP6 lacks; female, EU-based
Jeannie Paterson	University of Melbourne	AI governance and regulation, in-house; co-founding Director of CAIDE (Centre for AI and Digital Ethics), 2024 member of the Commonwealth AI Advisory Committee — not EU-AI-Act-specific, but the closer topical and practical fit; complements Postnikov and Walter’s platform-law gap in WP6
Danielle Citron	University of Virginia	AI-enabled gendered harm and deepfakes; author of the paper already cited in Chapter 1 (Chesney & Citron, 2019)
Beth Noveck	Northeastern University	Civic-tech side of Figure 4 (Noveck, 2021); complements Williams and Fu in WP7
Ben Wagner	TU Delft	General AI governance, the gap flagged above; directs the AI Futures Lab, works on algorithmic accountability in public decision-making — a European counterpart to Noveck for WP7
Tom Daly	University of Melbourne	Not an AI-civic-tech specialist like Noveck, but the closer in-house match: runs Democratic Decay & Renewal (DEM-DEC), directly on PARADE’s core topic, and directs the Electoral Regulation Research Network (ERRN) — a standing partnership with Australian electoral commissions; the fastest route to the public-body partner DEMOCRACY-09 requires (4.1), and strengthens WP1/WP3

Name	Institution / Country	Gap addressed
Isabelle Augenstein	University of Copenhagen	Multimodal, automated fact-checking (ERC-funded) — complements WP2
Andreas Vlachos	University of Cambridge	Automated claim verification (ERC-funded) — complements WP2
Zeeraak Talat	University of Edinburgh	NLP fairness/bias and online-harm detection — complements WP2's gendered-harm gap

Only Arugay and Lee Sue-Ann close the Southeast Asia gap. Recruit one of them first.

AI Use Statement

Claude Code (Sonnet 5), an AI assistant developed by Anthropic, was used as an assistance tool for figure production as well as structuring and editing the text for consistency and language refinement. It was also used to identify and research potential collaborators and gap-filling contacts, summarising their publicly available research profiles from institutional and academic sources online; every such profile was checked against those sources before inclusion, but the choice of whom to approach remained with the authors. All substantive decisions as well as all conceptual, methodological, and interpretive aspects of the manuscript remained with the authors. All AI-generated outputs were carefully reviewed and verified by the authors, who take full responsibility for the final content.

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